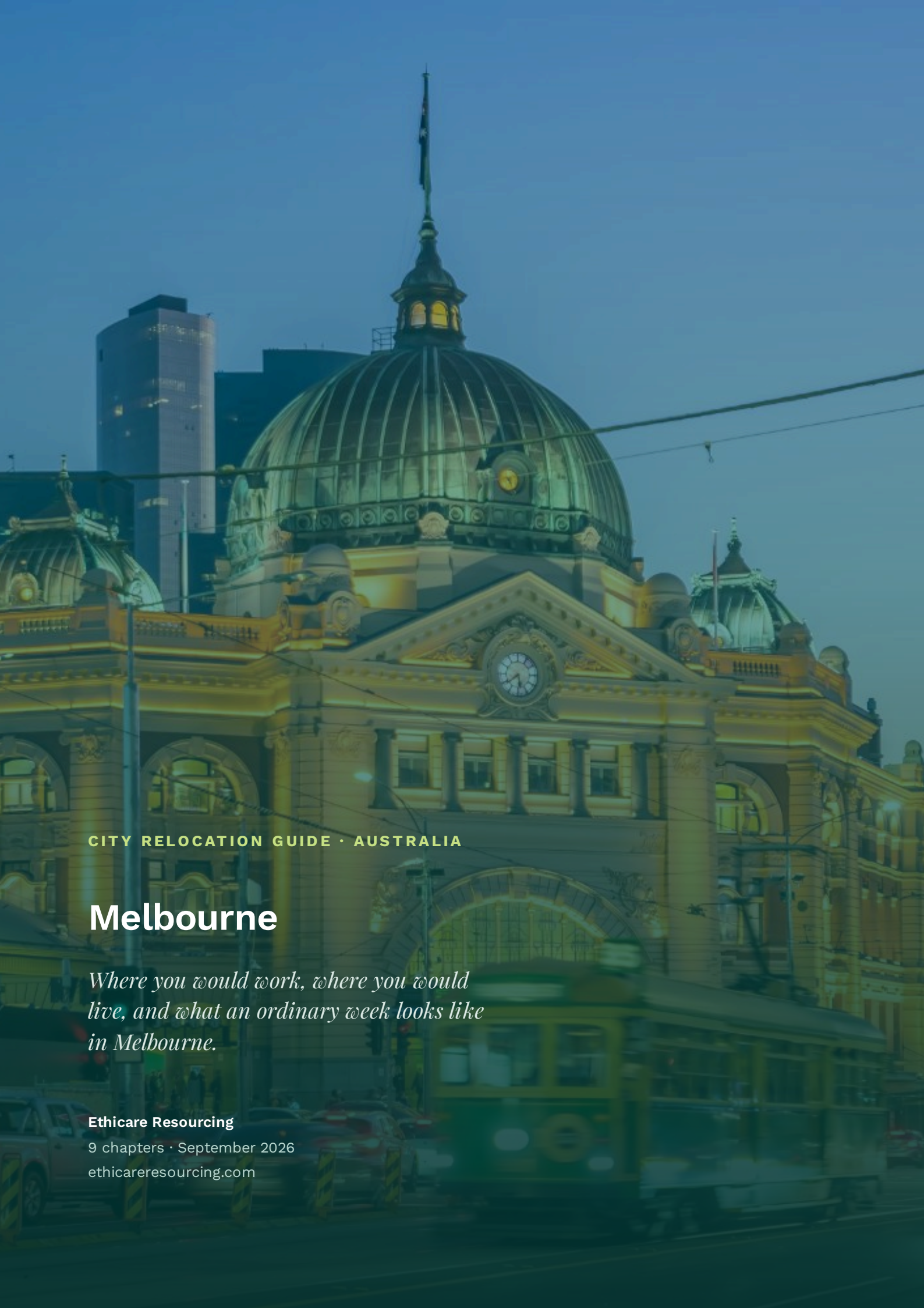




CITY RELOCATION GUIDE • AUSTRALIA

Melbourne

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Melbourne.

Ethicare Resourcing

9 chapters • September 2026

ethicareresourcing.com

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Melbourne

Melbourne Guide · Chapter 1 of 9

Melbourne is the choice for clinicians who want the system, not the beach. Australia's deepest concentration of tertiary and quaternary medicine, the country's largest medical research precinct, and a city built on trams, laneways and an argument about coffee. It asks you to accept the weather.

A city that rewards people who like cities



Birrarung Marr, a five-minute walk from the CBD

Around five million people live here, spread across a grid that Hoddle laid out in 1837 and a tram network that never got torn up — the largest in the world. The centre is dense and walkable, wrapped in gardens, and ringed by inner suburbs of Victorian terraces: Carlton, Fitzroy, Brunswick, Richmond, South Melbourne. Beyond them the city runs out to Port Phillip Bay in one direction and the Dandenong Ranges in the other.

For clinicians the draw is depth. Melbourne carries more tertiary and quaternary services than any other Australian city, an internationally significant biomedical research precinct clustered around them, and specialist centres that take referrals from across the country. If your sub-specialty is narrow, or you want research alongside clinical work, this is the strongest market in Australia.

The honest costs are the weather and the price. Four seasons in a day is not a joke: a July morning can be genuinely cold and a February afternoon genuinely dangerous. And Melbourne is expensive — less brutal than Sydney, well above Brisbane or Adelaide — so the housing arithmetic needs doing carefully before you commit.

Who wrote this

- We're a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest — but this guide isn't a pitch. There's nothing in it asking you to register, no form, and no visa advice.
- Melbourne is where we send clinicians who want the deepest system and the richest city life, and it is the city where the housing sums matter most. Where we think somewhere else fits you better, we say so.

The city, in nine numbers

~5M

People in Greater Melbourne — neck and neck with Sydney for the title of Australia's largest city.

250 km

Of tram track, the largest network on earth — and free travel inside the City Circle zone.

Deepest

Concentration of tertiary, quaternary and specialist services in the country, with the research precinct beside them.

4

Seasons in a day, reliably. The cliché exists because the weather genuinely turns in an hour.

1837

The Hoddle Grid — which is why the centre is legible, walkable and full of laneways behind the main streets.

~100 km

Of bay shoreline on Port Phillip, from Williamstown round to the Mornington Peninsula.

1 hr

To the Yarra Valley's vineyards, the Dandenongs, or the start of the Great Ocean Road.

UTC+10

With daylight saving — long summer evenings, and genuinely dark winter mornings.

~40%

Of residents were born overseas. Few cities absorb newcomers as easily, or feed them as well.

Six things you only learn once you're here

The weather is the price

Cold, grey stretches in winter and 40-degree days in summer, sometimes the same week.

Everyone owns layers and nobody trusts a forecast.

Trams organise everything

Where you live, how you commute, what you pay in rent. Living on a tram line is the single best housing decision here.

Coffee is a genuine standard

Not a joke and not a pose — the baseline is higher than almost anywhere in the world, and the local roaster matters more than the chain.

The laneways are the point

The best bars and restaurants are down alleys with no signage. Nobody will tell you where; you find them by walking.

Sport is the civic religion

The football fills the city from March to September, and the Cup, the Open and the Grand Prix each stop it for a week. You will pick a team.

It is a suburbs city

Five million people over a huge footprint. The inner ring is superb and the outer growth corridors are a different life — know which one you are choosing.

A note on Country

Melbourne stands on the lands of the Wurundjeri Woi Wurrung and Boon Wurrung peoples of the Kulin Nation, and Naarm is the name you will see used widely alongside Melbourne, including by health services. Acknowledgement of Country opens meetings, and Victoria's treaty and truth-telling processes are further advanced than any other state's — so this is live, current context, not history. Take the cultural induction seriously.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all about Melbourne specifically. Topics that are true across the state — regional Victoria, the state health structure — sit in the [Victoria guide](#). Anything true of Australia generally — Medicare, visas, Ahpra registration, tax, superannuation, schools — lives once in [Moving to Australia](#).

If you read nothing else, read [Why Melbourne](#) for the full case — and what we'd ask you to weigh, and [Where clinicians live](#), because in a city this size the tram line decides the life.

Why Melbourne

Melbourne Guide · Chapter 2 of 9

Melbourne wins on one argument more decisively than any other Australian city: the depth of the system. This chapter sets that against what it costs you — in rent, in weather, and in commute — and names the five reasons people choose somewhere else.

The argument

If your career needs a big system, Melbourne is the answer. More tertiary and quaternary services than anywhere else in the country, specialist centres that take national referrals, and a biomedical research precinct of genuine international standing sitting next to the hospitals that feed it. For sub-specialty work, higher training, research time or an academic thread alongside clinical practice, no other Australian city offers as many doors.

Around that sits a city that is good at being a city: trams that go everywhere, a food culture built by successive waves of migration, the best sporting calendar in the country, and gardens wrapped around a legible grid. Pay follows Victorian awards and enterprise agreements — we quote no figures here and will walk you through the current agreement for your profession instead.

Deepest

Tertiary and research system in Australia

250 km

Of tram network — the world's largest

~40%

Of residents born overseas

A typical week

A tram to work from an inner-north terrace, twenty minutes and no parking problem. A registrar teaching session in the afternoon and a research meeting you could actually join. Coffee that is quietly excellent from a place with eight seats. Friday night down a laneway with no sign on the door. Saturday at the market, then the football with ninety thousand other people. Sunday in the Dandenongs under tree ferns, or on the bay at Williamstown, or up in the Yarra Valley among the vines.

That is the trade in one paragraph: you give up the beach at the end of the street and reliable sunshine, and you get a city with genuine depth in every direction — clinical, cultural and culinary.

Sophie's insight

Melbourne is where I send people whose careers need room – the sub-specialists, the ones who want research alongside the clinical work, the ones who will be bored in a smaller system. It delivers that better than anywhere in Australia.

Be honest with yourself about two things first: the winter, and the rent. The clinicians who struggle here are the ones who came for the lifestyle photographs rather than the system.

Sophie Careem Founder & CEO, Ethicare Resourcing

When we'd point you north instead

The winter is real

Grey, wet stretches from May to August, dark mornings, and a wind off the Southern Ocean. If sunshine is what you are moving for, this is the wrong city.

It is expensive

Cheaper than Sydney, well above Brisbane and Adelaide. A family house in a good inner suburb is a serious financial commitment here.

The footprint is enormous

Five million people over a huge area. Get the suburb wrong and you will spend hours a week in traffic on a freeway.

The beach is a bay, not a coast

Port Phillip is calm, brown-sanded and cold. Real surf means the Peninsula or the Great Ocean Road, an hour-plus each way.

Big-system politics

Depth comes with scale: more layers, more competition for training posts, longer waits for the role you actually want. Smaller systems can move faster for you.

Where we'd steer you instead

If winter sun and housing arithmetic matter most, read [Brisbane](#) — tertiary work with a far gentler climate and price.

If you want a major-hospital career at the lowest cost of living, [South Australia](#) is the honest answer.

If it is regional Victoria that appeals rather than the capital, the [Victoria guide](#) covers the state's regional centres.

In our experience

Melbourne suits clinicians building a career with range — the system's depth means the next sub-specialty, fellowship or research post is usually a tram ride away, not an interstate move. Buy a good coat and it's the most complete city in the country.

Melbourne at a glance

Melbourne Guide · Chapter 3 of 9

Before the practical chapters, orientation. Melbourne is unusually legible for a city of five million: a grid at the centre, rings of suburbs around it, and a tram network that makes the whole inner city navigable within a week of arriving.

How the city is laid out

The grid and the river

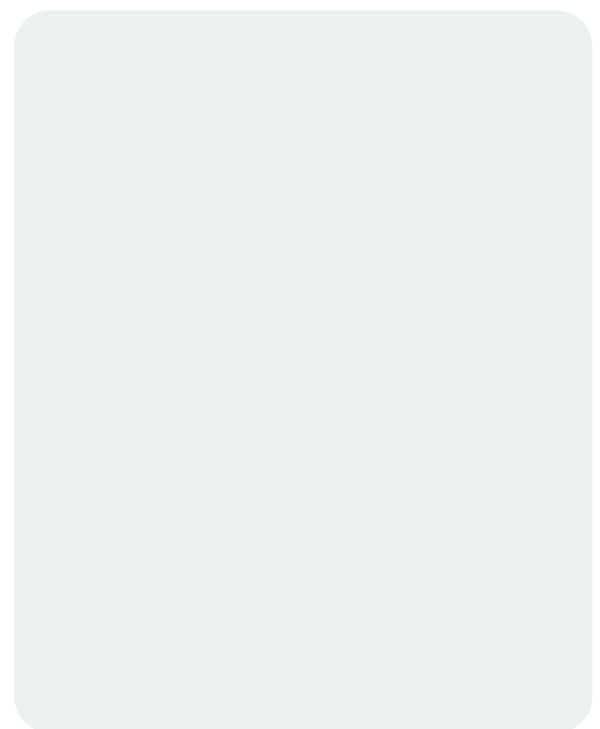
The centre is the Hoddle Grid, laid out in 1837 and still doing its job: numbered blocks, main streets with laneways behind them, and the Yarra along the southern edge. Southbank and Docklands extend it across and down the river; the gardens ring it on three sides. Most of the tertiary hospital work sits either inside this ring or immediately north and east of it.

The inner rings

North: Carlton, Fitzroy, Brunswick and Northcote — terraces, students, live music and the best of the food. East: Richmond, Hawthorn and Kew, leafier and dearer as you go. South: South Melbourne, Albert Park, St Kilda and Prahran, with the bay at the bottom. West: Footscray, Yarraville and Williamstown, the fastest-changing part of the city and still the best value inside ten kilometres.

The outer city

Beyond about fifteen kilometres, Melbourne becomes a different proposition: large growth corridors north, west and south-east, newer housing, bigger blocks, longer commutes and their own regional hospitals. The bay



Where Melbourne sits, with the straight-line distance to Geelong and Ballarat

curls south to the Mornington Peninsula; the Dandenong Ranges rise to the east; and Geelong sits an hour south-west as a city in its own right.

Four seasons in a day

The cliché is accurate, and it comes from geography: cold fronts arrive off the Southern Ocean and cross the city in an hour. Summer brings genuine heat — a run of 40-degree days most years, with total fire ban days across the state — and winter is cool, grey and damp rather than freezing, with dark mornings. Spring and autumn are the best of it, and unpredictable.

Summer

Dec – Feb

14–26°

Heatwaves · fire danger

Autumn

Mar – May

11–20°

The city's best season

Winter

Jun – Aug

7–14°

Grey, damp, dark early

Spring

Sep – Nov

10–20°

Unpredictable · racing season

Two practical notes. Heating matters here in a way it does not further north — ask what a rental has, because older terraces and weatherboards can be cold and expensive to run. And take fire-danger days seriously if you live on the city's fringe or plan weekends in the ranges: the warnings are precise and worth obeying.

Getting in and out

Melbourne Airport is about half an hour north-west of the city, with direct flights across Asia, the Middle East and the Pacific and constant shuttles to Sydney — one of the busiest air routes in the world. There is no train to the terminals yet, so budget for a bus or a taxi. Overland, Geelong is an hour, the Great Ocean Road starts ninety minutes away, Sydney is a full day's drive or a 90-minute flight, and the overnight ferry to Tasmania sails from Geelong.

Words you'll hear in week one

NaarmThe Woi Wurrung name for Melbourne, used widely including by health services

MykiThe tap-on card for trams, trains and buses across the city
Hook turnTurning right from the left lane, to keep the trams moving. Alarming once, then normal
The GThe MCG – the cricket ground that is also the winter football cathedral
ParmaChicken parmigiana, the pub standard. Do not call it a parmi here
The PeninsulaMornington – beaches, wineries and hot springs, an hour south
Total fire banA statewide summer declaration. It means exactly what it says
FootyAustralian rules, not rugby. Choosing a team is a genuine social act

Healthcare in Melbourne

Melbourne Guide · Chapter 4 of 9



Registration is national; hiring here is service by service. Melbourne's distinction is depth — the widest range of tertiary, quaternary and specialist services in the country, with an internationally significant research precinct beside them. This chapter explains the shape of it without naming employers.

How the system is organised

Victoria runs its public system through a large number of separately governed health services, each employing in its own right. In Melbourne that means several major metropolitan services, each with a tertiary campus and a group of community and specialist sites around it, plus standalone specialist services covering areas such as paediatrics, women's health, cancer, eye and ear, and mental health. There is also a substantial private hospital sector and a large private imaging and pathology market.

The practical consequence: "a job in Melbourne" is a job in one service, in one part of a city fifty kilometres across, and moving between services later is a fresh application. Get the service and the campus straight before you start looking at suburbs.

Quaternary depth

The widest range of highly specialised services in Australia — including work that takes referrals from other states.

Standalone specialist services

Paediatrics, women's health, cancer, eye and ear and mental health run as their own services here, which creates career paths that do not exist in smaller systems.

A research precinct

Medical research institutes clustered around the inner-city hospital campuses, with genuine clinician-researcher pathways and joint university appointments.

One national register

Ahpra registration works everywhere in Australia. The process, English evidence and assessment live once in [Eligibility & registration](#).

THE SERVICES THAT ONLY EXIST AT THIS SCALE

In most systems these sit as departments inside a general hospital. In Melbourne five of them run as health services in their own right – own governance, own recruitment, own career ladder – and that is the concrete version of “depth”.

Paediatrics	A standalone specialist service taking referrals well beyond the city, so a whole career can be built in children's work without moving between employers to get the case mix.
Women's health	Obstetrics, gynaecology and neonatal care run as their own service rather than a wing of a general hospital – which changes what a senior post in the field looks like.
Cancer	A dedicated service with the research institutes beside it. If you want treatment, trials and teaching in the same week, this is the structure that allows it.
Eye and ear	Narrow, high-volume specialist work concentrated in one place – the kind of bench that a general hospital in a smaller system simply cannot carry.
Mental health	Runs as its own service, which means clinical leadership and specialist pathways that sit outside the general acute hierarchy.

Each of these employs in its own right, alongside the major metropolitan services – so “a job in Melbourne” is a job in one of them, and a later move is a fresh application. Registration itself is national: [Eligibility & registration](#).

What that means for a career

If your field is narrow, or you want research and teaching braided into clinical work, Melbourne gives you more options than anywhere else in the country. Higher training posts, fellowships and joint appointments are more plentiful here simply because there are more services competing for and creating them.

The flip side is scale. More layers of governance, more competition for the sought-after posts, and a longer path to the specific role you want — where a smaller system might hand you breadth and responsibility immediately. That is a genuine trade, not a criticism, and it is worth being honest with yourself about which you want. [Why Melbourne](#) weighs it properly.

Two structural notes. Regional Victoria — Geelong, Ballarat, Bendigo, the Latrobe Valley — runs substantial services with their own recruitment and, in many cases, regional migration advantages the capital does not have; the [Victoria guide](#) covers those. And metropolitan Melbourne is not classed as regional for skilled migration, which changes the visa arithmetic — see [Visas & the move](#).

“

If the career needs room, Melbourne has the most of it. Everything else here is the price of that.

The one-line version

What to ask at interview

Pay follows Victorian awards and enterprise agreements — we deliberately quote no figures in this guide, and will walk you through the current agreement for your profession instead. What you can pin down at interview:

Salary packaging — public-health roles can package part of your pay pre-tax; ask how much and how to start it on day one

Which service, and which campus — the same title means different work across this city

The roster reality — shift patterns, penalties, on-call frequency and how gaps get covered

Research and teaching time — whether it is protected, funded, and how joint appointments work

CPD — funded time and money, and what conference travel is covered

Supervision and support in your first year, especially if you trained overseas

Parking and the commute at your shift times — inner-city campus parking is scarce and expensive

Professional indemnity — what the employer covers and what stays yours

Two things to do early

Start registration as soon as Melbourne is on your shortlist — paperwork, not ambition, is what moves start dates. And fix your campus before you fix your suburb: in a city this size with this many services, the commute you sign up for is the one you will live with for years.

Where clinicians live

Melbourne Guide · Chapter 5 of 9



In Melbourne the tram line decides the life. Get within walking distance of one that runs to your campus and the city becomes small and easy; get it wrong and you join a freeway every morning. Here is the map as we'd draw it over coffee.

ON THE MAP

THE INNER NORTH

- 1 Carlton
- 3 Collingwood
- 5 Northcote
- 7 Preston
- 2 Fitzroy
- 4 Brunswick
- 6 Coburg

THE INNER EAST

- 8 Richmond
- 10 Camberwell
- 12 Box Hill
- 9 Hawthorn
- 11 Kew
- 13 Doncaster

THE SOUTH & THE BAY

- 14 South Melbourne
- 16 Middle Park
- 18 St Kilda
- 20 Brighton
- 15 Albert Park
- 17 Port Melbourne
- 19 Elwood
- 21 Hampton

THE WEST

- 22 Footscray
- 24 Yarraville
- 23 Seddon
- 25 Williamstown

THE OUTER CORRIDORS

26 Craigieburn

28 Melton

30 Pakenham

27 Werribee

29 Dandenong

● Parks & nature ● Beaches ● Landmarks

Shaded areas are the suburbs named in this chapter. Arrows point to places beyond the map edge, with the straight-line distance from the city centre.

Suburb boundaries © Geoscape Australia, CC BY 4.0 · Natural Earth

The inner north

Carlton, Fitzroy, Collingwood, Brunswick and Northcote: bluestone lanes, Victorian terraces, live music, and the densest concentration of good food in the country. Close to the inner-city and northern hospital campuses, well served by trams, and the natural first landing for clinicians without children. Prices climb steeply as you approach the parks; Coburg and Preston further out are the value versions of the same idea.

The inner east

Richmond, Hawthorn, Camberwell and Kew — leafier, quieter, more expensive, and the traditional family answer. Excellent state and independent schools, big trees, and a straightforward run into the eastern hospital campuses. Beyond them Box Hill and Doncaster are more affordable and increasingly well connected, with a large and long-established Chinese-Australian community and the food that comes with it.

The south and the bay

South Melbourne, Albert Park, Middle Park and Port Melbourne put you between the city and the water, with trams both ways and the bay at the end of the street. St Kilda and Elwood are livelier and better value; Brighton and Hampton further south are family territory with the bathing boxes and the good schools. The bay is calm rather than surf — pleasant for a morning swim, not a substitute for a coast.

The west, honestly

Footscray, Seddon, Yarraville and Williamstown are the best value inside ten kilometres of the city, and the west has spent a decade shedding its old reputation: Vietnamese and East African food, a genuine village feel in the smaller pockets, and Williamstown's waterfront looking straight back at the skyline. The trade is fewer trams and more reliance on the train line, plus industrial neighbours in places. If your campus is in the west or the inner north, this is where your money goes furthest.

The outer corridors

Beyond fifteen kilometres, Melbourne turns into large growth areas — north around Craigieburn, west around Werribee and Melton, south-east through Dandenong and Pakenham. New houses, big blocks, young families, their own regional hospitals, and prices that make family life possible on one clinical salary. The cost is the commute, which can be genuinely long, and a thinner public transport offer. Say the hard thing: if you take an inner-city campus and an outer-corridor house, you will spend ten hours a week travelling.

The honest comparison

Tram

The single most important housing variable here

4 wks

Typical bond, lodged with the state authority

Ask

What the heating is — old terraces run cold

If you want...	Consider	Because
Food, music and no car	Carlton, Fitzroy, Brunswick	Trams everywhere, walk to everything
Family space and schools	Hawthorn, Camberwell, Kew	Leafy, established, eastern campuses close
The bay at the end of the street	Albert Park, Elwood, Brighton	Trams and water, family-shaped
Best value inside 10 km	Footscray, Yarraville, Williamstown	The west, on the train line, changing fast
Value with a tram	Coburg, Preston, Northcote	Inner-north life a few stops further out
A house on one salary	The growth corridors	New, big, affordable — and a long commute

Renting itself — applications, bonds, rights, the documents that win a competitive inspection — works the same across Australia and lives once in [Living in Australia](#). Two Melbourne-specific habits: ask what the heating is and what it costs to run, and check the tram or train route to your actual campus at your actual shift times before you sign.

Before you sign a lease

Which tram or train line, and does it reach your campus without a change?

What heating does it have — and is there any insulation? Old terraces can be brutal in July.

Is it in the state-school zone you need? Zones matter here and are checked by address.

What is the commute at 6.30am and 10pm, not at 9am?

Would a short-term rental first be wiser? Most people re-choose once they know the rings.

Getting around

Melbourne Guide · Chapter 6 of 9

Melbourne is the one Australian city where living without a car is genuinely easy — if you live in the right ring. The tram network is the largest on earth, the trains radiate properly, and the whole thing runs on one card. Outside the tram zone, the arithmetic changes.

The network, in four parts

Myki

One tap-on card across trams, trains and buses, with a daily fare cap. The Free Tram Zone covers the city centre entirely — no touch on, no charge.

Trams

250 km of track, 24 routes, the largest network in the world. Frequent, slow-ish, and the reason inner Melbourne works without a car.

Trains

Radial lines from the city loop out to the suburbs and on to the regional centres. Fast where trams are slow, and the backbone of outer-suburban commuting.

Bikes

Flat, gridded and well served by separated lanes along the Yarra and the inner north — one of the better Australian cities for a bike commute.

Car-free life is realistic anywhere inside about ten kilometres, especially north, east and south. In the growth corridors it is not: those are car suburbs with a train line, and most households run two.

Driving here

Australians drive on the left, and Melbourne adds one local specialty: the hook turn. To keep the tram tracks clear, you turn right from the left-hand lane, waiting in front of the intersection until the lights change. It is alarming exactly once. The other rule that matters: never pass a stationary tram on the near side when its doors are open.

The city has toll roads on its main cross-city routes, so a toll account is worth setting up early. Licence transfer and buying a car work the same across the country and live in [Living in Australia](#). Inner-city hospital parking is scarce and expensive — ask about staff parking at interview rather than assuming.

Distances that actually matter

From the CBD to...	Roughly	How
The inner north (Fitzroy, Brunswick)	10–20 min	Tram
The inner east (Richmond, Hawthorn)	15–25 min	Tram or train
The bay (Albert Park, St Kilda)	15–25 min	Tram
The west (Footscray, Williamstown)	10–25 min	Train
Melbourne Airport	~30 min	Bus or road – no train yet
Growth corridors	45–75 min	Train or freeway
Geelong / Mornington Peninsula	~1 hr	Train or drive
Sydney	~90 min	Fly – one of the world's busiest routes

The takeaway

Choose your home by the line that reaches your campus, not by the suburb's reputation. Inside the tram rings you may never need a car; outside them you will need two. That decision is worth more to your quality of life here than almost anything else in this guide.

Cost of living

Melbourne Guide · Chapter 7 of 9



Melbourne sits second on every Australian cost table: clearly below Sydney, clearly above Brisbane, Adelaide and Perth. The honest version is that you are paying for system depth and city life, and the two lines newcomers underestimate are heating and the second car.

Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the *shape* of a month, and the judgement about which lines will surprise you — which is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Melbourne against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

The headline

2nd

Dearest capital — below Sydney, above the rest

Tram

Living on a line can remove a whole car from the budget

Winter

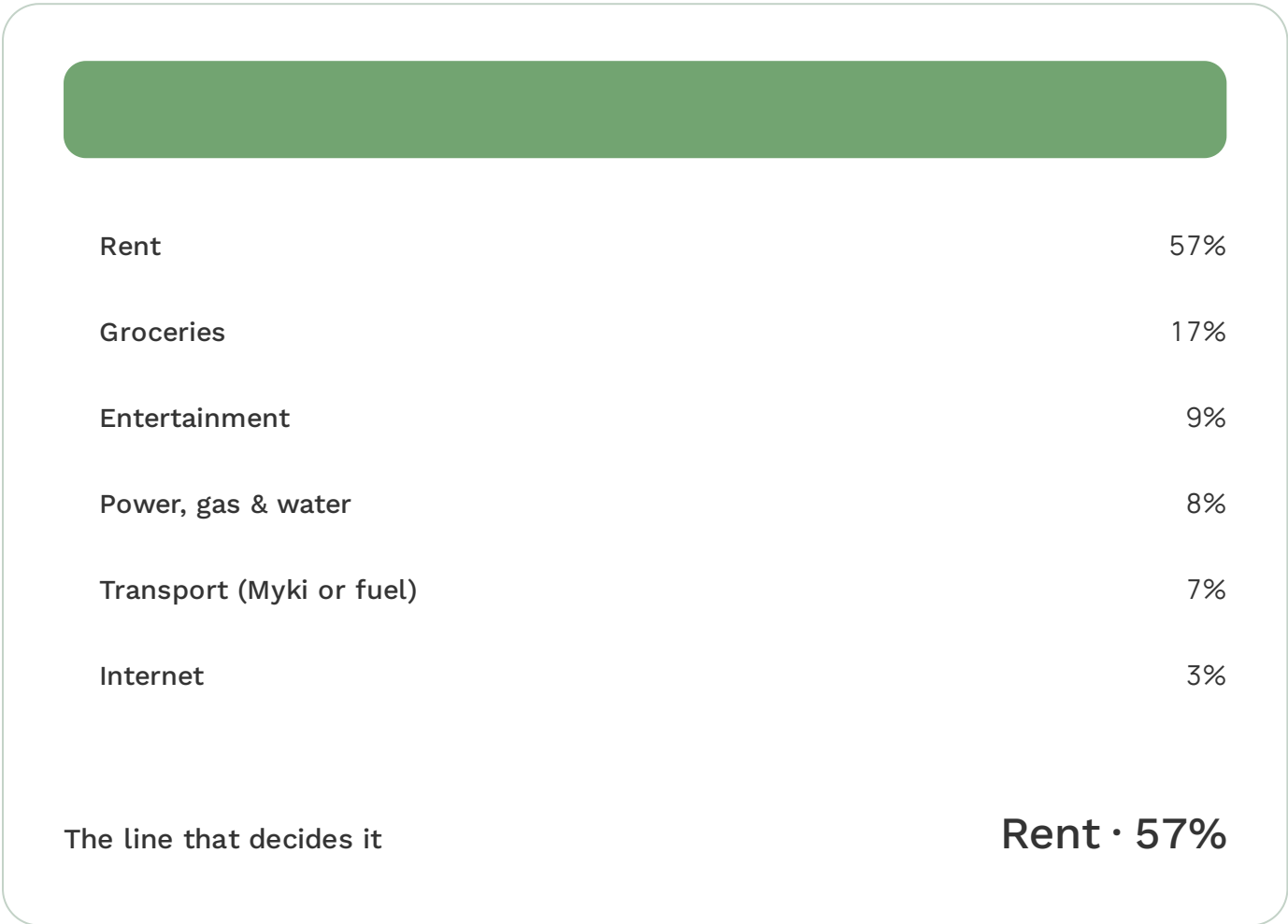
A heating bill that Brisbane and Perth never see

The structural point: an inner-ring family house here is a serious financial commitment, while an inner-ring flat on a tram line is very achievable on a clinical salary. Which of those you need changes the whole calculation.

What everyday life costs

WHERE A MONTH ACTUALLY GOES

The proportions, for one person on a mid-range budget. Proportions move slowly; prices move every quarter. Rent takes just under sixty per cent – clearly below Sydney, clearly above Brisbane, Adelaide and Perth.



Two of these lines are the ones newcomers underestimate: heating, because older terraces and weatherboards are poorly insulated, and the second car. Inside the tram rings you may run none; in the outer corridors most households run two.

The costs the brochure skips

Heating, and gas
Melbourne homes use gas heating widely, and older terraces and weatherboards are poorly insulated. A cold July in a draughty house is the bill that surprises people from warmer countries most.

The second car

Inside the tram rings you may run none. In the outer corridors most households run two, with tolls on the cross-city routes on top. This is the single biggest swing in a Melbourne budget.

The city itself

Melbourne is very good at separating you from money: restaurants, festivals, the football, the theatre. Budget for actually using the city, because using it is the reason you came.

Where the money comes back

Public transport is the big one — a genuinely car-free life is possible here in a way it is not in Brisbane, Perth or Adelaide, and that is thousands a year. Then the free city: the gardens, the galleries with free entry, the laneways, the beach on the bay, and a festival calendar that runs most of the year. Groceries at the markets beat the supermarkets, and Victoria grows most of what it eats an hour or two away.

On the income side, public-health and not-for-profit roles here can salary-package part of your pay before tax — ask payroll on day one. How packaging, tax and superannuation work is national and lives in **Pay & conditions**.

The bottom line

Plan the bridge as well as the destination: temporary accommodation, a bond of about four weeks' rent plus rent in advance, winter bedding and heating, and either a car or a Myki. Then decide honestly whether you need the inner-ring house or the inner-ring flat — in Melbourne that one choice moves the budget more than anything else.

Get today's numbers, and compare them to home

These are live and updated continuously, which is why we send you to them rather than competing with them. Put the city you are leaving in the other box.

Numbeo cost-of-living calculator (<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/>) — the most complete comparison tool, and the one most clinicians already use. Crowd-sourced, so read it as a ballpark rather than a quote.

Expatistan (<https://www.expatistan.com/cost-of-living>) — the same idea with a cleaner side-by-side. Worth running as a sanity check when Numbeo looks off.

Australian Bureau of Statistics (<https://www.abs.gov.au/statistics/economy/price-indexes-and-inflation>) — official, slower, and the one to trust on the direction of travel rather than any single price.

If what you find contradicts the judgement on this page, tell us. We would rather correct the page than defend it.

Food, coffee & the everyday

Melbourne Guide · Chapter 8 of 9

Melbourne's food culture is not a marketing line, it is the product of a century of migration — Italian, Greek, Vietnamese, Lebanese, Ethiopian, Chinese — layered onto a city dense enough to support small, specific places. It is the best-fed city in Australia, and the coffee is the entry point.

The coffee, properly explained

The standard here is genuinely high and genuinely unpretentious: espresso brought by Italian and Greek migrants in the 1950s, refined by a generation of local roasters, and now so normal that a mediocre cup is a scandal. Order a flat white, a long black or a magic (a short double ristretto with steamed milk — a local invention) and expect it to be good almost anywhere with a queue.

The corollary: chains barely register. Your loyalty will be to a specific place within four hundred metres of your front door, and you will defend it.

The markets

Queen Victoria Market in the city, Prahran and South Melbourne for the serious cooks, Footscray and Dandenong for the best value and the widest range in the state.

The laneways

The rule is simple: no signage, no bookings, up a staircase or down an alley. Ask a colleague; nobody publishes the good ones.

The neighbourhood streets

Lygon Street for Italian, Sydney Road for Lebanese and Turkish, Victoria Street for Vietnamese, Box Hill and Glen Waverley for Chinese, Footscray for East African.

The parma rule

Chicken parmigiana is the pub standard, and calling it a "parmi" marks you instantly as being from anywhere else. It is a parma here.

Flavours of home

This is the easiest Australian city in which to find whatever you grew up eating. About four in ten residents were born overseas, and the food infrastructure follows: halal butchers across the north and west, kosher grocers and bakeries in Caulfield and Balaclava, South Asian shops in the eastern and south-eastern suburbs, African grocers in Footscray and Dandenong, and Asian supermarkets essentially everywhere. Very little needs ordering online.

For newcomers the practical upside is community, not just ingredients: the shops are usually attached to the associations, places of worship and weekend gatherings that make a city feel liveable within a month rather than a year.

The everyday rhythm

Melbourne lives outdoors when it can and indoors well when it cannot – which is the whole trick of the place. Summer means rooftop bars, the beach at the bay and the tennis in January. Winter means the football, long lunches, wine bars, and galleries with free entry. Spring is the racing carnival and the comedy festival; autumn is the food-and-wine festival and the best weather of the year. There is always something on, and most of it is walkable from a tram stop.

The everyday, in one list

Find your local coffee place in week one. It matters more than the supermarket.

Serious shop: Queen Victoria, Prahran or South Melbourne markets. Best value: Footscray or Dandenong.

Learn one neighbourhood food street properly – Lygon, Sydney Road, Victoria Street, Box Hill.

Say parma. Book nothing on a laneway. Accept that you will discuss coffee.

Bay, ranges & the Great Ocean Road

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Melbourne's weekends work outward in rings, and the ring you pick sets the day: the bay for a morning, the ranges or the valley for a Sunday, and the Great Ocean Road for the weekend everyone does at least twice a year.

The bay and the Peninsula

Port Phillip is calm, shallow water rather than surf — good for a morning swim, a paddle or a walk, and lined with piers from Williamstown round to Brighton's bathing boxes. An hour south, the Mornington Peninsula turns it into a genuine weekend: cellar doors, hot springs, calm bay beaches on one side and proper Southern Ocean surf on the other at Portsea and Sorrento. The ferry across the heads to Queenscliff makes a neat loop of it.

The ranges and the valley

East of the city the Dandenong Ranges rise into mountain ash and tree ferns forty minutes from the CBD — cool, wet, quiet, with a steam railway and a lot of tea rooms. North-east, the Yarra Valley is the wine country: an hour out, serious cool-climate pinot and chardonnay, and long lunches with a view back toward the ranges. Further out again, the High Country delivers real alpine weekends with snow in winter.

The Great Ocean Road

It starts ninety minutes from the city and runs for two hundred kilometres along the Southern Ocean: surf breaks at Torquay and Bells Beach, the rainforest and waterfalls behind Lorne and Apollo Bay, koalas at Kennett River, and then the limestone stacks of the Twelve Apostles standing offshore. It is one of the world's great coastal drives, and it is a weekend rather than a holiday from here.

THE RINGS, IN DRIVING TIME

Melbourne's weekends work outward in rings, and the ring you pick sets the day. The marked row is the far end of the Great Ocean Road – the drive everyone here does at least twice a year.

The bay

Calm, shallow water rather than surf – piers from Williamstown round to Brighton



15–20 min

The Dandenong Ranges

Mountain ash and tree ferns; cool, wet and quiet



~40 min

The Yarra Valley

Cool-climate pinot and chardonnay, and a view back toward the ranges



~1 hour

The Mornington Peninsula

Hot springs and bay beaches on one side, Southern Ocean surf on the other



~1 hour

The Great Ocean Road begins

Torquay and Bells Beach – then two hundred kilometres of coast



~1 hr 30

The Twelve Apostles

The far end of one of the world's great coastal drives – a weekend from here, not a holiday



~3 hours

Indicative driving times, direct. The Great Ocean Road itself is the point rather than the distance – most people stay overnight at Apollo Bay rather than turning round.

The city's own calendar

Summer

The Australian Open in January, cricket at the G, rooftop bars and the beach. The city empties briefly and then fills again.

Winter

Football from March to September, and the whole city arranges its Saturdays around it. Plus galleries, wine bars and long lunches.

Spring & autumn

The racing carnival, the comedy festival, the food and wine festival, the Grand Prix – and the best weather of the year for all of them.

Ten weekends, to start

The Great Ocean Road to Apollo Bay, staying overnight rather than rushing

The Twelve Apostles at dusk, when the tour buses have gone

A Yarra Valley cellar-door lunch and the drive back over the ranges

The Dandenongs: Sherbrooke Forest, the steam railway and tree ferns

The Mornington Peninsula – hot springs, then surf at Sorrento back beach

Wilsons Promontory for a proper walk and empty white beaches

Phillip Island: the penguin parade and a surf beach without the crowds

A day on the bay – Williamstown, the ferry, Brighton's bathing boxes

The High Country in winter for snow, or in summer for the rivers

A Saturday at the football, whichever team a colleague talks you into

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Melbourne. Statewide and regional topics live in the [Victoria guide](#), and everything national in [Moving to Australia](#). When you're ready to talk about real roles here, [we're easy to reach](#) – and there's no pipeline waiting on the other end of the call.